

Gresham College

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Gresham College is an extraordinary and ancient educational institution. Founded by the will of Sir Thomas Gresham in 1579, it has survived numerous challenges for over 400 years and has lately enjoyed a renaissance.

Sir Thomas Gresham was born into a Norfolk merchant family in 1519. His father was a leading London merchant and was knighted by King Henry VIII for negotiating favourable loans. His uncle founded Gresham School, Holt. Thomas Gresham joined the Mercers Company in 1543 and started business as a merchant in Antwerp, where he also acted as an agent for the King. When the value of the English pound fell on the Antwerp Bourse in 1551, the Government sought his advice. His successful recovery plan helped repay nearly all government loans within a few years.

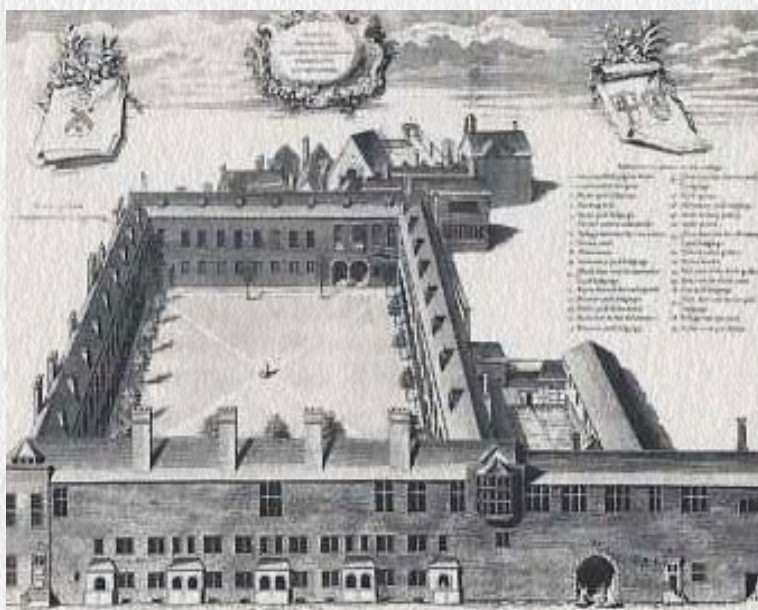
Gresham suggested to the City of London that a meeting place for merchants and financiers, modelled on the Antwerp Bourse, was needed. The City would provide the land, and he would build the Royal Exchange at his own expense. It opened in 1571.

Gresham considered founding a Cambridge College but instead left most of his fortune to establish a College in London for merchants and traders. His son and son-in-law had died before him.

His will of 1575 stated that the College should occupy his great house in Bishopsgate (now the site of the NatWest Tower). It would have seven Professors (four nominated by the City Corporation and three by the Mercers Company). The unmarried professors were to receive £50 a year, live in the house, and give free public lectures in rotation once a week.



Sir Thomas Gresham



Gresham College 1740

These detailed instructions left many governance issues unclear, causing later difficulties. The first Professors, all from Oxford or Cambridge, normally taught in Latin, though this was not widely used in the City. It was also unclear whether they had to live in the College or could take other paid work. Delays meant the first lecture was not given until 1597.

The Professorships offered an alternative career path for scholars. Famous Professors included Christopher Wren, while Robert Hooke owed much of his scientific career to Gresham College. The College also contributed to advances in the “new learning”, including the invention of logarithms.

The great house escaped destruction in the Great Fire of 1666 and temporarily housed both the Royal Exchange and the Royal Society. The next 300 years brought many disagreements and periods of low attendance.

In 1768, after years of debate, the great house was redeveloped, leaving the College without a permanent home for 80 years. Lectures continued at the Royal Exchange. A new Gresham College opened at Cheapside and Basinghall Street in 1842. Even then, lectures were given in Latin and repeated in English an hour later.

The renaissance of Gresham College began in 1989. It is now a company limited by guarantee and a charity, led by a Provost and Academic Board. Professors serve three-year terms. The College relocated to Barnard’s Inn, formerly the Mercers School, and now provides lectures by leading speakers. These are live-streamed, archived, and available worldwide. The founder would likely be amazed that the College now fulfils his vision on a far greater scale than he could have imagined.